

DPSH MUN 2026

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Future Leaders for Gender Equality.

JUNIOR UNITED NATIONS
COMMISSION ON THE
STATUS OF WOMEN



DPSH MUN 2026



AGENDA:

“Addressing gender-based discrimination with special focus on access to education, cultural autonomy and political representation in developing nations.”

United Nations Commission on the Status of Women,
DPSH MUN 2026,
Delhi Public School, Khajaguda,
Hyderabad.

BACKGROUND GUIDE

Agenda: Addressing gender-based discrimination with special focus on access to education, cultural autonomy and political representation in developing nations.

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Letter From the Executive Board

*It is with utmost pleasure that we welcome you to the **United Nations Commission on the Status of Women (UNCSW)** at **DPSH MUN 2026**. We sincerely hope you're all in good spirits and health, and that your preparation is going well. Even if it isn't, there's nothing to worry about, this background guide will serve as your guiding resource, shedding light on the topics and nuances that matter most for a fruitful debate. MUNs are designed to challenge you, to push your boundaries every single time you step into the committee room. To truly excel, you'll need to stay alert, think on your feet, and be observant enough to adapt as the debate evolves. This background guide aims to help you do exactly that. It covers everything from the basics of MUN procedure to the key details of our agenda.*

However, remember that this guide is a compass, not a map. It points you in the right direction but doesn't replace your own research. You may not quote this document as evidence during committee; instead, always rely on credible, verifiable sources when making statements or presenting data. A special note to first-time delegates: enjoy the experience. Don't stress. Every skilled delegate you'll see around started as a beginner. MUNs are spaces to learn, grow, and gain confidence, not just to compete. As your Executive Board, we're here not only to moderate but also to guide, encourage, and support you. Please feel free to reach out to us with any doubts, no matter how small; every question matters, and every idea is worth hearing.

The UNCSW stands as one of the oldest and most crucial commissions under the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC), dedicated to the promotion of gender equality and the empowerment of women across the globe. The agenda for this session, "Addressing Gender-Based Discrimination and Expanding Women's Rights to Mobility, Work, and Political Participation in Middle Eastern and Asian States," is not just a policy discussion, it's a moral and structural question at the heart of sustainable development, justice, and human rights.

Warm regards,

Mahika Tyagi

Akshaini Sinha

Vice-Chairperson

Vice-Chairperson

United Nations Commission on the Status of Women

(UNCSW) DPS Hyderabad MUN 2026

Introduction to the United Nation Commission on the Status of Women

The United Nations Commission on the Status of Women (UNCSW) is a functional commission of the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC), established in 1946 under Resolution 11(II). It serves as the principal intergovernmental body dedicated to promoting gender equality and the empowerment of women globally.

Over time, the Commission has become a leading platform for shaping international norms on women's rights, particularly after the 1995 Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, which remains the cornerstone of global gender policy. The UNCSW convenes annually at the UN Headquarters in New York, bringing together member states, UN entities, and civil society organizations to assess progress and adopt Agreed Conclusions, documents that guide national and international action on gender equality.

Mandate and Functions

The Commission's mandate focuses on:

- Promoting women's rights in political, economic, civil, social, and educational fields.
- Developing and monitoring international standards and policies on gender equality. Ensuring gender perspectives are integrated across all UN activities.
- Reviewing progress on implementing CEDAW (1979), the Beijing Platform for Action

(1995), and SDG 5 of the 2030 Agenda.

Its main functions include preparing reports and recommendations for ECOSOC, organizing the annual session on a priority theme, facilitating multi-stakeholder discussions, and negotiating Agreed Conclusions that outline commitments and policy strategies.

Decision-Making and Documentation

The UNCSW comprises 45 member states elected by ECOSOC for four-year terms, ensuring equitable regional representation. Decisions are made primarily by consensus.

Key documents include:

- Agreed Conclusions: Main outcome document of each session.
- Resolutions & Reports: Provide thematic and policy guidance.

-NGO Inputs: Written and oral statements from civil society, crucial to shaping discussions.

Mandate in the MUN Context

Within Model UN, delegates should note that UNCSW is not a legislative or enforcement body, it cannot impose sanctions or binding laws. Its power lies in advocacy, influence, and policy recommendation. Delegates must use this platform to:

- Propose reforms for discriminatory systems.
- Align national policies with CEDAW and Beijing commitments.
- Recommend awareness and capacity-building programs, especially where cultural or religious barriers persist.
- Foster regional cooperation among states to share best practices.

Relevance to the Agenda

In addressing gender-based discrimination and expanding women's mobility, work, and political participation, UNCSW serves as a catalyst for reform, collaborating with bodies like UN

Women, ILO, and UNDP to mobilize political will and promote equality.

“The UNCSW does not make laws, it makes laws possible.”

Important Points to Remember

Purpose

The Commission on the Status of Women (CSW) is a space for delegates to build policy, not pass judgment. The work of this committee is rooted in dialogue, cooperation, and reform.

The following points are meant to help you prepare and debate in a way that's both effective and true to your country's stance.

I. Understanding Your Portfolio: The PESTAL Framework

Before you walk into committee, take time to understand your country from every angle. A simple PESTAL analysis will help you see where your nation stands on the agenda and why.

1. Political Landscape:

Understand how your government approaches women's rights and gender equality. Check whether it has ratified global frameworks like CEDAW, the Beijing Platform for Action, or the SDGs.

2. Economic Factors:

Look at the financial realities. What are women's employment rates? Are there legal barriers or wage gaps? Does your country fund initiatives that support women in the workforce?

3. Social Demographics:

Culture, religion, and tradition play a huge role in shaping women's rights in this region. Learn how social norms, ethnicity, or religious law affect women's mobility and political participation.

4. Technological Development:

Consider how technology and infrastructure affect access, from safe public transport to digital literacy and access to online work.

5. Current Events:

Stay up to date with new laws, protests, and regional developments. Understanding what's happening now gives your arguments depth and realism.

6. Legal Framework:

Read into the laws that affect women's lives, family codes, labor laws, voting rights, and political quotas. Identify gaps between international commitments and national implementation.

II. Research and Preparation

1. Research, Speak, Rebut.

Solid research is your foundation. But your success depends on how you use it when you speak and question others.

2. Prepare Your Speeches.

Have at least 2–3 GSLSpeeches (60–90 seconds each) ready before the committee. Each should define one issue, show your country's position, and present a clear reform idea.

3. Have Subtopics Ready.

Be prepared to speak in moderated caucuses on smaller aspects, like education, employment, or political inclusion. Keep short 60-second ideas ready.

4. Listen and Respond.

Pay attention to what others say. The best rebuttals come from logic and timing, not aggression. Write down key contradictions or facts to question later.

5. Work on Draft Clauses.

Think of a few possible solutions beforehand, written in formal, UN-style language. Look at past CSW resolutions for reference.

6. Structure Your Speeches Well.

You can use any of these simple formats: HPA: Hook–Point–Action LEET: Label–Explain– Example – Tieback FLL: Fact–Legality– Logic (great for analysis)

- PEN: Punchline – Example – Nail in the Coffin (good for rebuttals)
- IRAC: Issue – Rule – Application – Conclusion (useful for legal framing)

III. Conduct in Committee

1. Follow Your Country's Policy.

Everything you say must reflect your assigned nation's beliefs. Don't make statements that contradict your country's political or cultural reality.

Example: A delegate representing Saudi Arabia might support reforms for workplace inclusion but can't propose abolishing the guardianship system overnight.

2. Procedure Comes Second to Discussion.

The committee will follow the UNA-USARules of Procedure, but don't hold back your points out of fear of getting the procedure wrong. The EB is here to help you, not intimidate you.

3. Role of the Executive Board.

The EB is there to guide debate, not dominate it. We will question, test, and push you to think deeper, but the direction of the committee comes from you, because at the end of the day we as the EB are only here to moderate you.

4. Use Reliable Sources.

Use credible and verifiable data to support your points. Acceptable sources include:

- UN and ECOSOC reports (UN Women, UNDP, OHCHR, UNESCO, etc.)
- Regional and multilateral bodies (OIC, ASEAN, SAARC, EU, BRICS, ILO, World Bank)
- Government publications and national statistics, State-operated news agencies like RIA Novosti, Xinhua, or Al Arabiya
- Verified NGOs and academic research (Amnesty, Human Rights Watch, RAND, World Books)

Avoid using Wikipedia, AI-generated content (such as ChatGPT or other AI tools), or opinion-based articles as formal evidence. These sources may be used for preliminary understanding or brainstorming, but they will not be accepted as credible evidence during debate or in official documents.

Background of the Agenda

Understanding the Issue

Gender-based discrimination continues to shape the daily realities of millions of women across the world. In many regions, women's ability to move, work, and participate freely in society is often limited not just by law, but by culture, religion, and tradition.

This agenda focuses on three core freedoms, the right to mobility, to work, and to political participation. These freedoms together define a woman's autonomy. Yet, across many states, women's access to them is still determined by outdated systems that prioritize control over equality. The problem is not the absence of rights in law; it is the everyday barriers that prevent women from exercising them.

Women's Right to Mobility

Freedom of movement is one of the most basic human rights. However, for many women in the Middle East, Africa and parts of Asia, it remains restricted both formally and socially. In countries such as Saudi Arabia, Iran, and Afghanistan, women's movement has historically been governed by male guardianship systems or restrictive laws.

Saudi Arabia's 2019 reforms allowed women to apply for passports and travel without male consent, but in practice, cultural resistance and administrative barriers continue to limit this freedom. In Afghanistan, after the Taliban returned to power in 2021, women were banned from most forms of public life. They cannot travel long distances without a male escort, attend higher education, or hold jobs in most sectors. Here, restrictions on movement are not simply about physical distance but about erasing women's presence from public spaces altogether. Even in countries without explicit legal bans, many women still face barriers to safe mobility because of harassment in public transport, unsafe streets, or social stigma attached to traveling alone.

When women cannot move freely, they lose access to education, healthcare, and employment. The loss of mobility is, in essence, the loss of independence.

Women and Work: Barriers to Economic Empowerment

Economic empowerment is often described as the engine of gender equality. Yet, across much of the nations, women remain on the margins of the workforce. The World Bank reports that women's labor force participation in the MENA region averages around 20 percent less than half the global average. Even where women are educated, their participation in paid work is disproportionately low.

This is partly because of restrictive labor laws that bar women from certain industries, limited maternity protection, and lack of childcare facilities. In many rural or conservative societies, social norms discourage women from working outside the home. Economic dependency traps women in cycles of vulnerability. Without their own income, women have less bargaining power within families and limited influence in political or community spaces. Economies also lose when half the population is excluded from production and innovation. Higher female participation leads to stronger economies, making women's employment both a social and economic priority.

Political Participation and Representation

Politics remains one of the toughest spaces for women to access. In many countries across the Middle East, Africa and Asia, women hold less than 20 percent of seats in national parliaments. In regions where political authority has traditionally been male-dominated, women entering politics face skepticism, harassment, and social criticism. Some governments have adopted gender quotas to improve representation, but in several cases these have led to symbolic inclusion rather than real influence. Women may hold office, but their authority is often undermined by patriarchal party structures. Moreover, in conflict-affected regions, the exclusion is even more severe. Peace negotiations and reconstruction efforts rarely include women, despite their vital role in community rebuilding.

Meaningful representation requires more than numbers. It means ensuring that women's voices shape decision-making, policy, and governance. Political participation gives women the power to influence the laws that define their lives, from labor protections to family codes.

Root Causes and Context

The persistence of gender-based discrimination in these regions cannot be traced to a single cause. It is a result of deeply rooted social structures, overlapping systems of law, and long histories of patriarchal control. In many Middle Eastern states, personal status and family laws are based on religious interpretations that place women under the legal authority of male relatives. These laws affect everything from inheritance and divorce to custody and nationality.

In South and Southeast Asia, discrimination often stems from social expectations that prioritize women's domestic roles. In some areas, religion is used to justify inequality; in others, tradition and community pressure achieve the same outcome. Conflicts in countries like Syria, Yemen, and Afghanistan have made things worse by dismantling institutions that once supported women's education and health. Economic inequality, political instability, and lack of access to justice reinforce the pattern, leaving women with limited choices and even fewer protections.

Why This Agenda Is Urgent

The agenda is built on the understanding that the right to mobility, work, and participation are inseparable. Without freedom of movement, women cannot study or work. Without employment, they lack independence. Without political power, they cannot influence change. These three freedoms together represent the foundation of equality.

The urgency of this agenda lies in the risk of regression. While the last two decades brought advancements in women's education and visibility, recent years have seen a rise in conservative politics, online harassment, and rollback of rights, especially in conflict zones. The Middle East and Asia stand at a turning point, between sustaining progress and slipping backward.

Addressing this requires both legal and cultural reform. Laws must evolve to eliminate gender bias, but social attitudes must also shift to see women as equal citizens, not dependents.

Solutions must consider regional diversity, from highly urbanized states like Japan or the UAE to rural, traditional communities in South Asia, while upholding universal principles of equality and human rights.

The Role of the UNCSW

The United Nations Commission on the Status of Women serves as the key global platform for shaping policy and guiding international cooperation on gender equality. In the context of this agenda, the Commission's role is to review existing barriers to women's mobility, employment, and political participation; encourage states to reform discriminatory laws; and support the creation of safe and equitable systems where women can live and lead freely. By facilitating collaboration between governments, civil society, and UN agencies, CSW aims to turn discussion into measurable change.

This agenda challenges delegates to think beyond sympathy and focus on solutions, reforms that balance cultural contexts with universal human rights. It calls for policies that not only protect women but empower them to move, work, and govern on their own terms.

When women are free to walk, to work, and to lead, they don't just change their own lives, they change their nations. The responsibility of this committee is to help make that change possible.

Timeline of the Agenda

In 1930, the First Eastern Women's Congress in Damascus brought together women activists from across the region to discuss education, labour, and legal rights, marking one of the earliest regional feminist initiatives. A year later, the All Asian Women's Conference in Lahore (1931) created the first pan-Asian platform linking women's movements across South and West Asia.

After World War II, the *United Nations Commission on the Status of Women (UNCSW)* was established in 1946, holding its first session in 1947 as the UN's principal body for women's rights. Early national milestones soon followed: Syria granted women universal suffrage in 1953, and Tunisia, after independence, extended voting rights to women in 1957 and enacted one of the region's first progressive family codes.

During the 1960s, modernization brought limited reforms. Iran's White Revolution (1963) legalized women's suffrage, while at the global level, the UN's International Women's Year (1975) and the Mexico City Conference marked the start of coordinated international action. The adoption of CEDAW (1979) and its entry into force in 1981 legally bound states to eliminate discrimination against women.

The 1990s consolidated this movement. The *Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action (1995)* set out the most comprehensive global framework for gender equality. In 1996, ECOSOC expanded the UNSCW's mandate to monitor Beijing's implementation. Regionally, Qatar granted women the right to vote in 1998 and hold municipal office in 1999: an important precedent for the Gulf states.

The early 2000s and 2010s witnessed both reform and repression. Qatar's 2003 constitution affirmed women's political rights. In Saudi Arabia, women were granted the right to drive in 2018, but many activists were simultaneously imprisoned. Across Asia, the #MeToo movement (2018) sparked public conversations about workplace harassment and equality.

The 2020s have brought both progress and setbacks. The *Beijing+25* review in 2020 coincided with the pandemic, which deepened economic and social inequalities. Turkey's withdrawal from the Istanbul Convention (2021) and the Taliban's return to power in Afghanistan (2021) marked serious regressions in women's rights. The death of Mahsa Amini (2022) ignited Iran's "Woman, Life, Freedom" protests, symbolizing the demand for bodily autonomy and civic freedom. In contrast, India's 2023 Women's Reservation Law reserved one-third of parliamentary and state assembly seats for women, one of the region's most ambitious political reforms.

As the world approaches *Beijing+30 (2025)*, both achievements and setbacks define the regional landscape. From the first congresses in the 1930s to today's global debates, women in the Middle East and Asia have fought for the same simple principles, the right to move, to work, and to lead. The task now before the international community is to ensure that these rights are no longer conditional, but universal and enduring.

Key Players

The issue of gender-based discrimination and women's rights in the world involves a wide range of actors, from governments and international organizations to advocacy groups and regional alliances. Understanding who the key players are, and how they shape the debate, is crucial to forming informed positions in the UNCSW.

Although all UN Member States share the responsibility to uphold gender equality, the Middle Eastern and African regions present a complex picture. Some states are moving toward reform, while others remain resistant due to political conservatism, cultural interpretations, or conflict. Alongside these governments, several international bodies and non-state organizations continue to push for change, providing funding, research, and policy frameworks that influence national agendas.

1. Saudi Arabia

Saudi Arabia has long been at the center of the debate over women's rights in the Middle East. For decades, the country's male guardianship system restricted women's movement, employment, and autonomy. However, recent years have brought significant, though carefully controlled, reforms. The right to drive was granted in 2018, and in 2019, restrictions on travel without a male guardian were officially lifted. Women have also been appointed to the Shura Council and other advisory positions. Despite this progress, many activists remain detained, and legal reforms continue to coexist with deep-rooted cultural conservatism. Saudi Arabia thus represents both the challenges and the cautious evolution of women's rights in a traditional society.

2. Iran

Iran presents one of the starkest examples of state-imposed control over women's autonomy. While Iranian women are among the most educated in the region, they continue to face restrictions on dress, movement, and participation in politics. The government's enforcement of strict dress codes, under the "Hijab and Chastity Law," reflects the broader use of morality as a political tool. The death of Mahsa Amini in 2022 and the subsequent protests brought the issue of women's bodily autonomy to global attention. Iran's case highlights how women's mobility and participation are often tied to larger struggles over civil liberties and state authority.

3. Afghanistan

Afghanistan is currently one of the most critical cases of gender regression in the world. Since the Taliban regained control in August 2021, almost all of the progress made over the past two decades has been undone. Women and girls have been banned from secondary schools and

universities, prohibited from working in most sectors, and restricted from traveling without a male escort. The Taliban's interpretation of Islamic law has erased women's presence from public life, drawing condemnation from the international community. Afghanistan stands as a painful reminder of how political instability and extremist ideology can instantly reverse years of advancement.

4. India

India plays a major role in shaping gender discourse in South Asia. The country has constitutional guarantees of equality and a growing number of women in politics, judiciary, and business. Yet, the gap between urban progress and rural reality remains wide. Issues such as workplace harassment, wage inequality, and gender-based violence continue to persist. The 2022 hijab ban controversy in Karnataka reignited debates over freedom, secularism, and women's agency in public spaces. India's position in the committee will likely emphasize balancing gender equality with cultural and religious pluralism, while continuing to promote women's political and economic empowerment.

5. Bangladesh and Pakistan

Both Bangladesh and Pakistan are important players in the South Asian context. Bangladesh has had women in the highest offices for decades, showing symbolic progress. However, challenges remain in ensuring safety, equal pay, and participation in rural economies. Pakistan, on the other hand, has strong constitutional commitments to women's rights but continues to struggle with societal conservatism and violence against women. Both nations reflect the tension between political visibility of women and their everyday vulnerability, making them key examples for policy discussion in the CSW.

6. United Arab Emirates (UAE)

Among Gulf states, the UAE has positioned itself as a reform-oriented example of women's inclusion. It has appointed women to half of its Federal National Council and created dedicated ministries for tolerance and community development. The UAE's efforts to expand women's participation in business and government have been praised internationally. However, critics argue that reforms remain top-down and controlled, rather than being part of a broader democratic shift. Still, its model shows how state-driven modernization can open limited but significant spaces for women in conservative societies.

7. Democratic Republic of Congo

The Democratic Republic of Congo shows a harsher version of the same tension seen in Bangladesh and Pakistan, but here it centers on survival rather than symbolism. Decades of armed conflict have made sexual violence against women widespread, and despite constitutional guarantees of equality, women remain almost entirely absent from top political and government positions.

Domestic violence, early marriage, and harmful traditional practices are also common, compounding women's vulnerability. The DRC thus illustrates an extreme case where legal commitments to gender equality exist on paper, but conflict, poverty, and weak institutions leave women both politically marginalized and physically unsafe — a sobering counterpoint for CSW discussions on translating rights into real protection.

The Maputo Protocol, formally the Protocol to the African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights on the Rights of Women in Africa, is a regional human rights treaty adopted by the African Union in 2003. It was created to strengthen and make explicit protections for women that were only broadly implied in the original African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights.

8. Federal Republic of Nigeria

Nigeria shows the same gap between women's numbers and their power. Despite being Africa's most populous country, Nigeria has never had a woman as President or Vice President, and very few women hold seats in parliament or top government posts. Gender-based violence and harmful practices like female genital mutilation also remain common. Nigeria's case shows that even a large, influential democracy can leave women largely shut out of real political leadership, making it an important reference point for CSW conversations on closing the gap between electoral weight and actual decision-making power.

9. Ethiopia

Ethiopia shows a similar gap between formal commitment and lived reality. Violence against women remains widespread and takes many forms, from intimate partner violence to conflict-related sexual violence, with recent reporting on abuses linked to the war in northern Ethiopia. Surveys have found that a majority of women believe wife beating can be justified under certain circumstances, showing how deeply such violence is normalized rather than treated as exceptional. At the same time, Ethiopia has taken visible steps toward inclusion, running national programmes on women's leadership, economic empowerment, and protection from violence, alongside past recognition for appointing women to high political office. This makes it a useful example for CSW discussions on why political visibility alone doesn't guarantee safety or equality.

10. Regional and International Organizations

Several international and regional institutions actively influence the direction of women's rights in these regions. The United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women (UN Women)

plays a leading role in coordinating global advocacy, conducting research, and supporting local initiatives. It partners with governments across Asia and the Middle East to promote women's economic participation, legal reform, and leadership development.

The Economic and Social Commission for Western Asia (ESCWA) and the Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific (ESCAP) both work closely with governments on integrating gender equality into sustainable development plans. The International Labour Organization (ILO) focuses on workplace reforms, maternity protections, and anti-discrimination laws, while the World Bank funds programs to improve women's access to finance, education, and entrepreneurship.

At the regional level, organizations like the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) and the League of Arab States are significant but often cautious players. Their approach to gender equality tends to emphasize cultural sensitivity and gradual reform, rather than adopting a strict universalist position. The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) has also initiated programs on gender empowerment, though regional cooperation has been limited by political rivalries.

11. Civil Society and Women's Rights Movements

Civil society movements and grassroots organizations form the backbone of women's rights advocacy in these regions. In Iran, groups like "My Stealthy Freedom" and "White Wednesdays" have mobilized women to challenge compulsory dress codes. In Afghanistan, underground networks continue to provide education to girls despite Taliban bans. Across South Asia, NGOs such as SEWA (Self Employed Women's Association) and BRAC have improved women's access to economic and educational opportunities. These local efforts often succeed where governments hesitate, making them vital partners in the struggle for reform.

12. The Role of the UNCSW and the Global Community

The Commission on the Status of Women provides a neutral and collaborative space where these key players can come together. While the CSW itself cannot impose change, it can shape international dialogue, funding priorities, and normative pressure. Through its sessions and agreed conclusions, it connects national reform with global frameworks such as CEDAW, the Beijing Platform for Action, and Agenda 2030.

Issues Stemming from Governance and Legislations

In many parts of the Middle East, Africa and Asia, laws themselves have become tools that sustain inequality. While progress has been made, the legal and governance systems in several states continue to reinforce patriarchal control and deny women equal protection. The problem lies not only in what is written in law, but in what is enforced, and who those laws are designed to serve.

Family and personal status laws are the clearest examples. In some countries, these laws allow a rapist to escape punishment by marrying his victim, or exclude marital rape from the definition of a crime altogether. Men are often the only ones allowed to pass nationality to their spouses or children, which leaves many women and their families stateless. Such laws treat women as dependents rather than citizens. A few countries have tried to separate religion from the state by adopting secular family systems that give women the right to own property, divorce, inherit, and share custody equally with men. But even these systems still contain traces of bias, like lower legal marriage ages for girls or unequal inheritance rights. In states governed by religious or customary law, adultery is criminalized, often punished harshly, and almost always more severely for women.

Discrimination also appears in health and medical laws. In many states, women are denied access to essential services like contraception, safe abortion, or treatment for sexually transmitted diseases. Doctors may refuse care due to stigma, and governments restrict reproductive rights through criminalization or limited access. These policies push women toward unsafe, unregulated healthcare, putting their lives at risk. High maternal mortality rates across the region reflect this neglect. At the same time, over-medicalization has become another form of control. Procedures like cesarean sections are performed far more often than necessary, turning women's health into a business rather than a right. True autonomy in healthcare is still rare, as women are often denied the right to choose how and when to give birth or whether to end a pregnancy.

Abortion laws remain among the most politicized and damaging. Where termination of pregnancy is criminalized, women can be imprisoned even for miscarriages. The law reduces them to reproductive agents and denies them the right to make decisions about their own bodies. Safe abortion becomes a privilege of the rich, while poorer women are forced to seek unsafe alternatives. This makes reproductive inequality a reflection of class inequality too.

Cultural and religious governance further deepens these barriers. In many societies, men are regarded as the heads of households and the authoritative voices in cultural life, while women's choices, from what to wear to where to go, are tightly controlled. In some countries, female artists and singers are banned from performing publicly, and women are excluded from interpreting religious texts or participating in rituals. These rules are not about faith; they are about preserving control. Even if daily mobility becomes political, restrictions on women driving, traveling alone, or appearing in public spaces without male supervision remain widespread. Social policing and fear of harassment keep women out of public and cultural spaces.

Finally, there are forms of discrimination that hide behind tradition, such as witchcraft accusations or customary justice practices. In certain communities, women, especially widows and older women, are still accused of witchcraft, leading to violence or exclusion. These practices reflect how fear and superstition are used to target women who step outside expected roles.

In Iran, the death of 22-year-old Mahsa Jina Amini in police custody on 16 September 2022 sparked nationwide protests under the slogan "Woman, Life, Freedom." The demonstrations called for an end to forced hijab laws and broader state control over women's lives. The violent crackdown that followed exposed how deeply gender and political repression are intertwined. A UN inquiry later confirmed her death was unlawful, making this movement a defining moment in the fight for bodily autonomy and public participation.

Across all these areas, one pattern repeats: when law and governance fail to protect women, they are used to control them. Real reform must therefore focus on changing not only the words of the law but the mindset behind it. The goal is not to erase culture or faith, but to ensure that neither is used to justify inequality. Legal systems must guarantee that women can make choices, about their families, their bodies, their work, and their public lives, without fear or permission. Until governance reflects that principle, equality will remain an aspiration rather than a reality how fragile women's rights become when political systems collapse and extremist ideologies dominate.

Case Studies

In Saudi Arabia, Loujain al-Hathloul and other activists led the Women2Drive campaign, demanding the right to drive and an end to male guardianship. In 2017, a royal decree lifted the driving ban, and from June 2018, women began receiving licences, a historic shift for the kingdom. Yet, at the same time, Loujain and several activists were arrested, detained, and charged under vague national security laws. Her case revealed the contradiction between progress on paper and the shrinking space for activism, showing that reform without civic freedom remains incomplete.

In **Afghanistan**, the Taliban's return to power in August 2021 erased two decades of progress. Women and girls were banned from secondary and higher education, many were dismissed from public jobs, and strict restrictions on mobility and dress returned. The situation demonstrates

In **China**, the 2015 detention of five young activists known as the *Feminist Five*, arrested for planning anti-harassment campaigns, highlighted how feminist organizing itself can be criminalized. Their brief detention led to a long-term chilling effect on women's rights movements and civil society in China. The case symbolized how governments can endorse equality in words while suppressing the movements that demand it in practice.

In **Turkey**, the government's 2021 withdrawal from the *Istanbul Convention*, a key international treaty against violence towards women, marked a serious setback. Officials claimed the treaty threatened "family values," but the decision sparked large protests and international criticism. It showed how domestic politics can undo years of commitment to protecting women's rights and how international agreements depend on the political will to enforce them.

Questions A Resolution Must Answer (QARMA)

1. How can family and personal status laws be reformed to ensure equal rights in marriage, divorce, inheritance, and custody?
2. Why have secular or partially reformed systems failed to eliminate gender bias in practice?
3. How can states guarantee women's freedom of movement without guardianship or moral policing laws?
4. What steps can ensure women's access to safe, affordable reproductive and healthcare services?
5. How can legislation protect women's medical rights without cultural or religious interference?
6. What measures can prevent harmful cultural practices from being codified into law?
7. How can governments train healthcare workers to provide gender-sensitive and non-discriminatory services?
8. How can states collaborate with advocacy groups and legal experts to expand women's healthcare rights?
9. What can be done to increase women's presence and leadership in governance and peacebuilding?
10. Why do punishments for crimes against women differ so widely across nations?
11. Should laws against violence towards women prioritize strict punishment or restorative justice?
12. How can international treaties like CEDAW be applied effectively within diverse cultural contexts?
13. Has your nation ratified all Optional Protocols to CEDAW, and if not, why?
14. What community or educational policies can change societal mindsets toward gender equality?

15. How can mobility, economic independence, and political participation be promoted together as core rights?

Hierarchy of Evidence

During committee sessions, delegates are encouraged to present evidence to support their statements, proposals, and clauses. However, not all evidence carries the same level of credibility. The strength of an argument depends on the reliability of its source. To maintain accuracy and ensure that debate remains fact-based, the following hierarchy outlines how evidence should be prioritized and evaluated in this committee.

Tier 1:

This includes any publication, statement, resolution, or document released by official organs or committees of the United Nations, such as the General Assembly, Security Council, ECOSOC, or the UNCSW itself. It also includes documents, statements, or press releases issued by UN member states in their official capacity like, for example, policy briefs, government reports, or statements made by accredited national representatives. Evidence from Tier 1 is considered the most reliable and authoritative and should be used wherever possible.

Tier 2:

This includes news articles or reports from state-owned or state-controlled media outlets of UN member states, such as *Xinhua News Agency (China)*, *Prasar Bharti (India)*, *BBC (United Kingdom)*, *RT (Russia)*, or *NHK (Japan)*. These sources represent a government's official perspective and are considered reasonably reliable when no Tier 1 source is available for a particular event or policy position. Delegates should use Tier 2 sources to reflect national stances, ensuring they align with the country's foreign policy.

Tier 3:

This includes international or independent media organizations of global reputation, such as Reuters, The New York Times, The Guardian, Agence France-Presse (AFP), or Al Jazeera. While these outlets often provide comprehensive reporting, they may reflect editorial or regional biases. As such, Tier 3 evidence is considered least reliable for formal arguments but may still be used when higher-tier sources are unavailable. Delegates citing Tier 3 sources should ensure their information is verified across multiple reports or supported by data from recognized international organizations.

In short, evidence from official and intergovernmental sources (Tier 1) always holds the highest weight in the committee. Delegates are strongly encouraged to prioritize UN reports, government documents, and official statements to substantiate their claims and maintain the credibility of their arguments.

Rules of Procedure

The United Nations Commission on the Status of Women (UNCSW) in this Model United Nations will function under the UNA–USA Rules of Procedure. These rules are designed to simulate the formal workings of UN committees, guiding how delegates debate, introduce motions, and negotiate resolutions.

The Rules of Procedure determine the flow of debate, including the structure of General Speakers' Lists, Moderated and Unmoderated Caucuses, points, motions, yields, and the process for drafting, amending, and voting on resolutions. They ensure that discussion remains organized, inclusive, and diplomatic throughout the conference.

Delegates are expected to review the attached Rules of Procedure document in detail before the first session. A clear understanding of these rules will help you participate more confidently, respond strategically to motions, and contribute effectively to the committee's progress.

The Executive Board will provide a short overview of the ROP during the initial session, but it is strongly advised that all delegates familiarize themselves with the procedures in advance to ensure a smooth and productive debate.

 [Rules of Procedure .pdf](#)

Bibliography

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